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The Yale Political Monthly

An Undergraduate Publication

The Yale Budget Crisis
Part I: The Dining Hall Debacle
Who Is Responsible and Why the Cuts Were Made

Inventing the Public Will
How Pollsters Subvert Democracy

Toward a World Government
The UN Must Be Strengthened to Fulfill its Historic Role

The Collapse of American Values
Morality Must Be Restored

VOLUME 13, NUMBER 1 ❦ OCTOBER 1991

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We encourage responses and will print all thoughtful and well-written letters with appropriate authorial response in the hope of stimulating continued dialogue on campus. All written material should be submitted to the Editor or mailed to the YPM. Students wishing to join the staff of the YPM should contact the Editor at 436-3081.

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The Yale Political Monthly
An Undergraduate Publication

VOLUME 13, NUMBER 1
OCTOBER, 1991

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Part I of the YPM series examines the cuts made to the dining halls and student reactions to those cuts. Administrators justify the cuts and promise that they are here to stay, while students and workers seek to overturn the decision.

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Only a greatly strengthened United Nationas can bring about and maintain lasting world peace.

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The rise of greed and ego-centrism is destroying American society and America's ability to compete in the world economy.

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Yale's Budget Crisis Part I: The Dining Hall Debacle

Jeff Campione

This article is the first in a series examining the financial changes which Yale finds itself enduring. In this issue, the YPM *will focus on the story behind the recent controversial changes in the Yale University Dining Hall (YUDH) services, examining the players involved, the factions that have developed, and the reasons behind the changes. Although it is impossible to even speak of the YUDH cuts without further examining the budget cuts throughout the university, a more detailed analysis of the latter will follow as part two of this series next month. – Eds.*

The food is horrible; the service is atrocious; they're out of bagels; the orange juice is warm; the eggs are cold; there's no ice; the rice is yesterday's, and it wasn't any good then, either. I cannot stand this place!

And that was last year.

Perhaps the most disheartening of the effects which the changes have caused is the information vacuum which has enveloped the campus in rhetoric, not fact

Upon arrival this time, the student body of Yale College awoke to an even more pleasant greeting from its dining hall system, as the budget axe tore through yet another victim. In response, the students, the workers and even some administrators have cried foul, screaming to have their opinions heard and possibly even considered in this chaos. According to much of the rumor, it has decimated the very fabric from which Yale derives its existence and now threatens to destroy this community in apocalyptic horror, the dimensions of which church leaders fearfully edited from the Book of Revelation.

Perhaps the most disheartening of the effects which the changes have caused is the information vacuum which has enveloped the campus in rhetoric, not fact. The *Yale Herald* issue of 6 September quoted a spokesman of the Graduate Employees and Students Organization describing the budget reduction: "'It's an attempt to create a dependence on the large departments, like Western Civilization. They would like to see it made permanent.'" First, there is no large Western Civilization department. The "Western Civilization program," for lack of a better term, which is scheduled to begin in several years, was, in fact, completely paid for by a grant from Mr. Lee Bass. This will not be a large department, but will consist of eleven faculty members. In addition, Mr. Bass gave this money for the express purpose of creating this program. Since the Bass Professors in Western Civilization appointed so far were already at Yale, their salaries will no longer be paid out of the Yale endowment but that set up by Mr. Bass, and the newly freed money in the main endowment is being used to renovate William L. Harkness Hall and Linsly-Chittenden Hall. The creation of a Western Civilization program has, therefore, actually saved money; it is not responsible for cuts in any other program. The assertions of the GESO spokesman are factually incorrect, if not ridiculous.

Indeed, many students have also gotten the impression that Donald Kagan, Dean of Yale College, or Betty Trachtenberg, Dean of Student Affairs, is responsible for the budget cuts in the University Dining Hall service. But neither of them falls within any rung of the power structure which determines budgetary action. That hierarchy originates in the President's Office, and extends though the Provost's Office and the Budget Office, and then goes down to the individual departments. Believe it or not, both Dean Kagan and Dean Trachtenberg have actually purchased the student-produced T-shirts that protest the

closing of Commons. They are each named, however, as scapegoats in student surveys, and student publications show Kagan looking smug in a chair while they blast headlines above saying that he said the closing of Commons would not be reversed, as if he had done this all himself and was flaunting it.

Far more serious, however, is the absence of official documentation of the budget crisis. Students have justifiably used this issue as a case for acquiring a voice in the administration. In the meantime, very few students feel they understand the administration's reasons for the dining hall cuts, or the budget cuts in general.

The cuts began in the 1989-90 school year. It was the initial decision of the President's Office, the Provost's Office and the Corporation that the budget needed to be cut. During this "first phase," as Dean Kagan terms it, all of the non-academic cuts began to take shape, including massive budget reductions in his office, and that of other administration members, and in graduate school departments. What has preoccupied the student body much more, however, is the subsequent "second phase" of reductions, proposed during the first part of last year and taking effect this year. Included in these changes were those in library services, athletic teams and, of course, those in University Dining Hall services.

In late December 1990, Provost Frank Turner and Vice President Michael Finnerty notified the heads of many departments that their budgets would be reduced, including Allan Kenney , Director of YUDH. Each division of the Budget Office determined the size of the cuts which needed to be made by each department it oversees. Mr. Kenney's immediate supervisor, Howard Parish, who serves directly under Mr. Finnerty, determined that the YUDH budget had to be cut by $1.2 million and asked Mr. Kenney to present a practical plan for implementing the cuts by 30 January.

According to Mr. Kenney, this scenario was familiar to his staff. Similar budget cuts were passed in 1971 and 1976, and at that time, YUDH prepared several contingency options so that it could deal with large-scale cuts in the future. The 1971 changes, the elimination of waiters and the introduction of self-bussing, was seen at the time as a transformation even more drastic than the closing of Commons is now perceived, a change which would forever destroy the quality of life at Yale, never permitting this ancient institution to reclaim its past glory. In 1976, YUDH adopted a second plan on the list and closed the Faculty Club dining hall. Mr. Kenney and his staff considered several other plans on the list before 30 January, including closing one residential college dining hall completely and the elimination of seconds at all meals. The plan which Mr. Kenney and his staff finally proposed to the Budget and Provost's Offices attempted to spread the burden somewhat more evenly throughout the Yale community. In its initial state, it called for the complete elimination of breakfast in the residential colleges, the elimination of hot lunch in Commons, the restriction of continental breakfast on the weekends to three colleges, and the elimination of dinner at Commons.

The driving force prompted Kenney and his staff to focus on these areas. The utter inefficiency of the use of labor during breakfast and in Commons, having both Commons and the colleges open for meals throughout the day, forced YUDH to run two complete shifts in each dining hall: breakfast-lunch, and lunch-dinner. Additionally, only 150 students a day were eating during the 7:30-9:00 hot breakfast and 9:00-10:00 continental breakfast periods, and far fewer than that during continental breakfast on the weekends. YUDH could have turned to a more radical solution, like closing one dining hall, which probably would have angered quite a few students, Masters, Deans and Fellows, but would have effectively left 91.67% of Yale somewhat content. This, however, would have eradicated the Residential College life of 400 students. The closing of Commons, however integrates the Freshmen into their colleges , and although it may deprive them of an experience many of us enjoyed as Freshmen, it gives them the opportunity to experience residential college life earlier in their Yale experience.

Mr. Kenney stated that throughout the process of choosing a plan, YUDH felt it necessary to maintain three primary goals: "Preserving the quality of undergraduate life despite budget restrictions; making improvements whenever possible; achieving the required substantial budget reduction." The events to follow, however, showed that at best, he could only achieve the first two.

Between 30 January and the middle of March, the YUDH proposal, along with those of many other departments, the scrutinized

Each division of the Budget Office determined the size of the cuts which needed to be made by each department it oversees

YPM Poll: Changes in the Dining Halls

Questions are in italics.

Do you support the changes in Yale University Dining Hall services?

	Freshmen	Total
Support	19%	5%
Do not support	52%	80%
Undecided	29%	15%

What do you feel are the three greatest inconveniences caused by the changes?

This was a write-in question

	Freshmen	Total
Overcrowding	53%	49%
Breakfast cuts	21%	35%
Loss of "Commons experience"	47%	35%
Makes dinner meetings more difficult	16%	21%
Difficulty in transfers	2%	14%
Loss of AFL	2%	9%

What do you feel are the three greatest benefits of the changes?

This was a write-in question

	Freshmen	Total
Avoided other cuts	15%	10%
Facilitates meeting people in your college	15%	3%

Whom do you believe was most responsible for the changes?

	Total
Benno Schmidt	40%
The Yale Corporation	24%
Donald Kagan	9%
Frank Turner	8%
Allan Kenney	7%
Other/Don't know	6%
Betty Trachtenberg	4%
Local 35	2%

Provost's Office and the Budget Office. After sorting details, Mr. Kenney and Budget Director Nancy Johnson met with the Council of Masters in March to present the plan as the best option available. The Council of Masters served only as an advisory body in these hearings, for they admit that the expertise in dealing with budget reductions lies within the department, and because to revoke the plan a date that late in the process would have been difficult to do. Changes, however, were most certainly brought to the floor, since the Masters could serve as an intermediary between YUDH, the administration, and the students who would endure the changes. Dean Kagan, who sits in at all Council of Masters meetings, but who had not been part of the budgeting process until that point, agreed with the Masters' uneasiness. "I myself...joined the Masters in saying that we were not happy about this, mainly because we all felt that it would cause a great deal of crowding at dinnertime in the dining halls and take away from the good event that that's supposed to be... That was our main point; we thought that the rest of it was something that we could live with, but we preferred, of course to keep on going the way we were."

The Council was successful, however, in amending two specific areas of concern. They argued that the breakfast changes as they stood would place too much stress upon the students, and as a result, continental breakfast was returned to all colleges on both weekends and weekdays. These changes, however, forced YUDH not to meet its targeted $1.2 million in cuts. According to Mr. Kenney, the actual reduction resulting from the current plan is slightly above $900,000. Deputy Provost Charles Long confirmed this: "When [the plan] was all done, it took about a million dollars out of the dining hall operations... It was scheduled for more reductions than that, but partly as a result of conversing with the Masters, some features that were originally in the dining hall plan–pieces that were taken out–were put back in." There is, then, the possibility that the Provost will ask for the remaining 25%. But Charles Long gave no indication that this was to happen.

The YUDH proposal required intricate change in the structure of its workforce, and if possible, the elimination of the two overlapping shifts in every dining hall. The budget decrease did not interfere with scheduled yearly salary adjustments, which meant that the expected 5%

budget cut was really going to be nearly 8 or 9%. No individual who worked for YUDH was fired, since attrition reduced the workforce. Two managerial positions were eliminated; one person was promoted and his department restructured, and another had already planned to leave permanently the organization for health reasons. All seven clerical workers were assigned other duties and their positions were eliminated. Additionally, YUDH eliminated the student coordinator position. This was made possible because 14 of 22 coordinators graduated, one dropped out of Yale, one no longer wanted to be employed by YUDH; and the others have been assigned other duties. Since 99 student employees graduated, student layoffs were avoided by reducing the number of new hires. Some non-student workers have been transferred to other tasks. Finally, some Local 35 employees, according to Mr. Kenney, volunteered to have their hours reduced, in most cases from 30 to 27 hours a week.

The President of Local 35, Tom Gaudioso, is nevertheless extremely critical of the situation in which his people are left. He says that the new lunch-dinner shift which the residential college employees now face runs much later in the evening, causing severe scheduling difficulties: like, forcing parents to be away from their children well into the night. All in all, Gaudioso says that thirty people had their hours modified by the changes in YUDH procedure. A more pressing problem, however, has been the increased workload which has resulted from the natural attrition of staff. Workers claim that not enough time has been provided to permit them to complete all of the new tasks they have been forced to absorb. The Union has instructed its workers to work only under the staffing requirements of previous years, forcing some sort of confrontation, either with their immediate supervisors, dining hall directors, or perhaps ultimately Mr. Kenney or President Schmidt.

The position which the unions have taken has always been much broader in focus. There was no union (or student) input when YUDH was choosing strategies in January. Indeed, Local 35 was not even notified of the changes which were to take effect until June. Mr. Gaudioso believes that the university had an obligation to consult with both its workers and its students in order to receive first-hand input about what could have or should have happened. Indeed, he believes that the

If you disapprove of the changes, should the University:

	Freshmen	Total
Reverse the changes	48%	46%
Amend the new policy	30%	30%
Create an entirely different approach to cutting the YUDH budget	22%	23%

Top suggestions for amending the new policy:

	Total
Re-open Commons	8%
Open Commons on alternate nights	3%
Cut students' jobs	2%
Cut waste	1%

This poll was conducted on 13 September 1991 in 10 Residential Colleges (Timothy Dwight and Pierson are not included in these tallies). A total of 518 undergraduates responded to the questions exactly as reproduced here. Sample questionnaires, as well as the completed surveys, are available for inspection. Contact the Editor at 436-3081 for more information.

The poll was conducted by:
Todd Suomela, Jonathan Edwards '94
Tommy Sangchumpuphen, Pierson '95
Glenn Tse, Saybrook '95
George Collins, Silliman '94
Jeff Campione, Davenport '94
Carlos Viana, Ezra Stiles '94
Jason Kramer, Morse '95
Michael Chartier, Calhoun '95
Adrian Hazbun, Trumbull '95
Neil Fulton, Pierson '94
Elliott Wu, Berkeley '93
Vaughan Turekian, Berkeley '93
Gautam Dutta, Saybrook '94

Data compiled by Gautam Dutta and Carlos Viana.

entire"budget crisis" is "fake and unsubstantiated."

The Unions' opinion about Yale's financial woes has always been clear: the university wastes too much money. As President Gaudioso claimed, the members of the administration "don't know how to manage money...or serve students." He cites the creation of a "service master" position at the Medical School, an outside contractor brought into the university make recommendations about how supervisors can best perform and handle their authority. Mr. Gaudioso argues that due to the misdirection and poor leadership of the service master, there has been a substantial increase in the number of injuries in the job. This hiring of the service master, to the Locals 34 and 35, is an example of how the administration wastes too much and is manufacturing a budget crisis just to gain grounding for upcoming negotiations.

The endowment is growing at a good pace relative to other schools, but compared with Yale's endowment of seven years ago, it is doing poorly

Evidence does exist, however, to show that the administration is not just fabricating their data, that there really may be a budget crisis. Mr. Long cites several specific expenses that have been increasing at a far greater rate than the budget can accommodate. The largest expense and quickest to accumulate, is health care. "One of the biggest parts of our compensation for people is fringe benefits; it represents 25-30% of our compensation package. And the biggest part of that, or at least one of the very big parts of that, is health benefits, and those have been growing at about 12-15% over the last few years... Health benefits are a vital part of a compensation package and how we treat employees—and students, for that matter." Since the cost of health benefits has been at least double that of inflation for many years, Yale will continue to increase that proportion of its budget which is set aside for health care. Mr. Long continues, "We increase [the health care] budget dramatically more than other parts of the budget every year, and every year actual expenses are even more than we thought they would be."

The entire "budget crisis" is "fake and unsubstantiated"

The second major area of increased spending is book and journal acquisition, the prices of which have been inflated in the last several years. Thirdly, the so-called "safety budget" which, according to Mr. Long, covers "everything from radioactive waste to government regulations governing safety in the workplace," is increasing much more rapidly than the majority of Yale expenses. Fourth, security has been strengthened to an all-time high , and has, even before the unfortunate homicides of the last several months, been budgeted at "better-than-inflationary increases" for the next several years. Fifth, salaries, which typically grow faster than inflation, have, especially in the case of faculty, been substantially increased in the last several years to maintain competitiveness.

Finally, renovating Yale's physical plant has delivered a large blow to the budget. "Those [buildings] are very expensive to renovate," says Long, "not only because they happen to be built with granite and brick and solid stone, but because they were built before there were anything like current regulations with regard to fire, and other types of safety, and of course, the access for the disabled."

Mr. Long also points to the fact that Yale is not the only college in the country facing difficult financial problems. "We're not alone in this. I don't know of an institution that isn't currently looking at exactly the same kind of imbalance. This is not a result of Yale's being profit-ridden and pouring its money down the drain, or being wretchedly managed... It's primarily an economic problem that we're all facing. And it's also true, even for institutions that weren't substantially built in the thirties, that the problem of the deterioration of the physical facilities is a big part of everybody's budget problem, not just ours... In fact it's been so recognized that the accounting standards for institutions of higher education are now insisting that we recognize the deterioration and the replacement value of buildings in our accounting system."

The other side of the budget coin is revenue, and the administration has begun to seek help from outside communities. President Schmidt spent the summer recruiting donors in East Asia, and is set to begin another fund-raising campaign in the coming months. The endowment is growing at a good pace, however, relative to other schools in the present time. Compared with Yale's endowment of seven to ten years ago, it is doing much more poorly. This can be blamed on both the unstable economy and the 1986 changes in tax laws. When the marginal tax on the wealthiest tax group is reduced, the tax incentive for investing in an institution such as Yale is greatly diminished. As a result, Yale cannot rely on the endowment as much as it has in the past ten years.

Insofar as the Administration may be able to prove the need for budget cuts, however, it has not been faultless in its attempts to solve this crisis. When the Union leaders met with Peter Valone, Assistant to the President, in June to express their disgust with the YUDH changes, Mr. Valone's response was relatively hostile. According to Mr. Gaudioso, "He said, 'Unless you agree that there's a financial crisis, I'm not going to talk to you about waste.'"

This statement , however, highlights the basic conflict which the administration faces with to the unions. The members of the unions see the day-to-day implementation of Yale's plans in each department, and can be quickly called upon to suggest tactical solutions to waste problems. Gaudioso and Local 34 have requested for some time now that physical plant vehicles have their own on-campus garage and mechanics. Currently, Yale sends drivers out to Hamden or West Haven and pays the entire transportation cost, as well as the higher prices for non-university mechanics. Yet the university has continually turned down the union's request. Valone's comment clearly illustrates that the university feels threatened by the unions. Yale needs to be receptive, to take constructive criticism and accept alternatives, but at the same time it has the hard task of guarding the future of the University, and it cannot become dependant upon or defensive toward the union. Dean Kagan describes the union as: "A monopoly that is organized for the purpose of maximizing the benefits of the members of the group who exercise that right. Their proper activity is get as much benefit for their members as they possibly can. Their proper role is not to think about what's best for the university." It is precisely for this reason that the unions were not consulted during the formulation of the YUDH plan.

Student input is a much more difficult issue, and those that are fighting for it are entering unchartered territory, to their advantage. Employers commonly do not consult with an employee's union when budgetary changes take place. All of the YUDH changes have met with considerable student opposition. That the students are angered, perhaps just as much as the Unions, is natural because students are paying the same amount for much reduced services. They have thus spoken out on a variety of issues, from overcrowding in the residential college dining halls to the loss of the "Commons experience" for Freshmen, to the lack of bagels at breakfast in some colleges. Several petition drives, an eat-in rally and substantial coverage by student publications have all become the voice of a unified student body against the cuts in service. Is the student backlash–especially after the events of Alumni Weekend and after those planned for Parents' Weekend take place–powerful enough to induce a complete reversal of the YUDH cuts? That is doubtful, if for no other reason than that the previous system was extremely expensive. As Dean Kagan pointed out, "I wouldn't use the word reversability, because that suggests that you go back to the previous condition. I would think that there is a certain amount of adaptability and adjustability... If somebody can think of a better way to do it..., can come up with variations on this [plan] that would produce the financial results that we would need, but would be better, we'll change."

One problem with making these amendments is that the students are undermining their own cause by doing an excellent job of adapting. The dinner lines, which both the Council of Masters and most of the students feared before school began, have not been nearly as long as anticipated. Despite the

Yale needs to be receptive to student opinion, but it also has the hard task of guarding the future of the University

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opposition of the Masters and many students to the changes in breakfast hours, too few people eat breakfast to justify opening twelve dining halls and the administration has the documentation to prove it. The entire process is beginning to look like, as Dean Kagan said, a "relatively painless" means of cutting nearly $1 million. What has been a problem is the line for lunch at Commons, and as furor over this increases, the students will probably attempt to obtain the power which they have sought. President Schmidt has scheduled a forum with the YCC, and has planned to review and if necessary to update the changes at the close of the semester. If such adjustments are actually to be made, the student body will have to convince the administration that even if the more obvious problems like overcrowding and inconvenience to the students have been solved, its other concerns. The loss of the freshman bonding experience, the lack of a meeting place for large groups, and the elimination of the Alternate Food Line carry enough weight to justify making the cuts elsewhere.

The easy solution would have been layoffs, and the YUDH plan successfully made every possible effort to avoid laying off workers

Mr. Long feels that the experience of this YUDH controversy has opened up the possibilities of increased input by affected parties when further budget cuts are made. "The more we can learn from the constituencies that are most affected, the better, and we need to work hard to find ways of improving the information in that direction. We will learn something from the dining halls this year, maybe it will lead to a particular cut, maybe it won't. I can assure you that what we've learned from the reaction is that we have to be even better than we've been at trying to figure out what the impacts are, if possible, to try and find a way... we need to find a way of most effectively taking some very proper people who are students, who are deans and who are representatives of the people in order to make sure that we've gotten some suggestions and some feedback from them." The Provost's Office, long infamous for its seclusion from the students, will actually take the lead in fostering this new attempt at communication. In the upcoming weeks, the office plans to publish for the community-at-large a documentation of the university's entire budget situation. The document will be a more readable version of that presented to the Corporation on 27 September.

At the same time it is becoming more difficult to cast aside immediately the President, the Corporation, the Provost's Office and Mr. Kenney as evil, heartless villains attempting to find an easy solution. As Dean Kagan quickly pointed out, "Even if you thought we were a bunch of swine, self-interest makes us want not to annoy the students any more than we have to. But in fact, actually, we don't want to." The easy solution would have been layoffs, and the YUDH plan successfully made every possible effort to avoid laying off workers. It is not in any way easy to modify one's family life because of a job that may now end later in the evening, or have to cover twice as many responsibilities at work. But Mr. Long says, "It is one thing to suffer the pain of a unit that's getting smaller; it's another thing to lose your job." And although Local 35 has denounced the cuts in student job opportunities for 1991-92 as both a cause of the increased workload and an example of lack of concern on the part of the administration, their own contract specifies that Yale must cut student jobs if those cuts will prevent the University from cutting non-student jobs.

In order actually to gage the truth in the administration's arguments, the students do need to become more involved. Members of the Yale community who feel strongly about the dining hall cuts must attend the YCC Forum this fall, lest they lose their first and perhaps their only chance to respond clearly and directly to administration activities. If there are areas from which Yale can cut the budget and thus reverse the YUDH cuts, the students must be vocal, must research the budget problem and the proposed solutions diligently, and must discuss such matters with others, such as the unions, who feel the same. Only an opposition that well-organized will be able to counter the administration's claims that these changes are working and are in fact not inflicting a great pain while still saving nearly $1 million.

Finally, the long-awaited opening of the books for the public will determine the validity of the claim that Yale is in the midst of a budget crisis. This of course is the justification behind everything the university has proposed and enacted, and if the university substantiates its claims, it would render its critics silent or ridiculous.

Perhaps the students can think of a way to cut the YUDH budget without so drastically affecting student life. So far, however, the student body has adapted reasonably well to the changes, and will be hard pressed to convince

the administration to reverse its new policy. In the future, a prudent administration ought to consult the students before it makes policy changes substantially affecting student life. Although Yale ought to consider union opinion, the unions ought also to consider the well-being of the university for which they work. Yale should not, however, be dictated by student or union opinion, for it needs to protect its long-term financial and institutional well-being more than it needs to cater to the convenience of its present employees and students. The university, in the case of the YUDH budget cuts, has looked after the welfare of both students and employees. Chiefly, YUDH has not fired any workers, and has reduced the hours only of those employees who volunteered to do so. The administration has gone to great lengths not to upset student life more drastically than need be. The current plan which closes Commons for dinner and changes dining hall hours and services was the least bad plan among many unpleasant alternatives. The administration clearly considered the welfare of the students when making this decision and tried to balance the needs of the students with those of the university. The administration failed to rally the support of the students, however, because it has not succeeded in convincing the Yale community that the budget is indeed in crisis and cuts are necessary.

This article was prepared by the staff of the Yale Political Monthly. Itis the first part of our series on Yale's budget crisis, which will be continued in the next issue. Anyone who is interested in taking part in this series should contact the Editor as soon as possible.

The article was written by Jeff Campione. The poll was coordinated by Gautam Dutta and Carlos Viana. The following interviews were used:

Allan Kenney, Director of Yale University Dining Halls (interviewed by Jeff Campione on 9 September)
Donald Kagan, Dean of Yale College (interviewed by Carlos Viana on 12 September)
Charles Long, Deputy Provost (interviewed by Carlos Viana on 16 September)
Tom Gaudioso, President of Local 35 (interviwed by Jeff Campione on 14 September)

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Inventing the Public Will

Michael Anderson

Democracy, it seems, has reached a new age. Never before has the meticulous divination of the will of the people been such an important antecedent condition of policy formation. One need look no further (although one is welcome to look very far, indeed) than Operation Desert Shield/Storm to witness the new found political importance of public opinion. Hardly was a day allowed pass, nor a major step taken, without the assurance of public support. For many, this is a dream come true. It could easily be argued that the prominence of the public opinion poll heralds the achievement of Lord Bryce's democratic utopia,

which would be reached if all the will of the majority of the citizens were to become ascertainable at all times, and without the need of its passing through a body of representatives, possibly without the need of voting machinery at all...The authority would seem all the while to remain in the mass of the citizens...To such a condition of things the phrase "Rule of Public Opinion" might be most properly applied, for public opinion would not only reign but govern.[1] I would like, however, to urge caution on those eager for such conclusions. Consider for a moment the words of Rudolf Chaika, a Soviet citizen disturbed by the March plebescite for the independence of Latvia. The question, which reads "Are you for a democratic, independent state of Latvia?" is, according to Mr. Chaika, too simplistic. "Can I vote 'no' to democracy?" he asks rhetorically, "and if I say 'yes,' how can I know what sort of democracy will follow?"[2] Mr. Chaika's complaint should remind us that those opinions which are credited with guiding policy are never pure expressions, but always come imbedded in a certain form, a given context. Alternative methods of polling can result in quite different manifestations of the same (individual) opinion. Thus, before we celebrate the triumph of pure democracy, the tools by which opinion is transmitted to those by whom public policy is most directly shaped require careful examination.

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The most important, and by far the most pervasive, of these tools is the binary media poll. These polls are distinguished by the simple fact that possible responses to the questions they pose are restricted to two pre-ordained, mutually exclusive (hence 'binary') options: yes/no; approve/disapprove. That American democracy is so dominated by these binary polls is an important fact, attention to which is likely to be rewarded by vital insight into the current condition of the modern democratic state.

Just what does the emergence of the binary media poll as a central part of contemporary politics signal about the state of participatory democracy? What can we learn about the political role of public opinion, and the role of the individual opinions which (apparently) constitute this aggregate, by gazing back at the populace through the same binary conduit through which its opinions flow?

Public Opinion, as a concept designating the collective will of a people, is a relatively recent invention. Not surprisingly, it is a product of the Enlightenment when, along with the rise of democracy itself, the idea of a general consensus, and the possible ways in which it might become manifest, first became an important political and philosophical concern.

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Among the first proponents of public opinion as an important democratic tool was Jean-Jacques Rousseau, who "put public opinion in its modern political place, demanding that law should spring from the general will." (Spier p.151) Jeremy Bentham, too, was a great supporter of public opinion, asserting that the "system of law emanating from the body of the people" is "the only check...to the pernicious exercise of the power of government" and an "indispensable supplement" to the process of "beneficial" rule. Nevertheless, to anyone sympathetic with Foucault's villification of Bentham's project, this ostensible support of the power of the populace will have a hollow ring, and with good reason. When discussing the role of the magistrate in the new political order, Bentham writes: "His greatest difficulty will be in conciliating the public opinion, in correcting it when erroneous, and in giving it that bent which shall be most favorable to produce obedience to his mandates."[3] Even Rousseau is far from untouched by such sentiments, noting that "whoever makes it his business to give laws to a people must know how to sway opinions and through them govern the passions of men."[4]

Thus, as the sun is inextricably tied to shadow, the dawn of public opinion saw the inevitable rise of the desire to control it. Each gain in the political importance and influence of public opinion was necessarily accompanied by an intensification of this will to power. It was not until the early twentieth century, however, that this will became effectively manifest, embodied in a man by the name of Edward L. Bernays.

Bernays could be called, with little exaggeration, the creator of modern advertising. "It was Bernays who in the 1920's [sic] invented the media event, the latent message, appeals of indirection, and initiated market research."(Blumenthal p.28). As Sigmund Freud's nephew, he had early access to the work of the great psychologist, and lost no time in applying those ideas to his work. "I was applying to the masses," says Bernays, "what he was applying to the individual" (Blumenthal p.36). It was Bernays' stated goal to apply scientific methods – a combination of psychology and sociology – to the "task of getting people to support ideas and programs." He manipulated the collective unconscious by employing overt symbols and "associative processes," and in so doing created public opinion itself (Blumenthal p.28). "It has been found possible" writes Bernays in his 1928 book *Propaganda* (a book proudly displayed by Joseph Goebbels), "so to mold the mind of the masses that they will throw their newly gained strength in the desired direction."[5] In Bernays we come one step closer to providing public opinion with the desired political bent. The methods for analyzing public opinion, and the techniques for manipulating it, nevertheless remained distinct sciences for many years. And, since, as Bernays unhappily admits, "the politicians were a generation behind," the application of his methods was largely restricted to advertising and product promotion (Blumenthal p.41).

All of this would change, however, with the growing influence of the political consultant and, in particular, with the important contributions of Patrick Caddell. Caddell was, among other things, Carter's pollster for both the '76 and '80 campaigns, and enjoyed an intimate relationship with the oval office not shared by any previous pollster (Blumenthal p.45). Caddell's major innovation is the near perfect fusion of the binary poll (first used extensively by George Gallup), the reigning method for determining opinion, with the Bernaysian methods for regimenting that opinion. His technique consists in "segmenting the electorate" until he has defined (and therefore created) every section of the population (Blumenthal p.53). By calling forth the voice of the public, the pollster (and the politician he represents) decides on the language which that public will speak. By exercising complete control over both the presentation of the issues and the range of possible responses to those issues, opinion can be defined and directed to suit present needs. Through rigorous use of such "razor sharp" binary polls, Caddell was able to construct the desired consensus. The polls themselves became the tool of manipulation. "Caddell," writes Sydney Blumenthal, "has pushed polling far beyond the one- dimensional survey used to make informed forecasts. He doesn't make predictions, he makes events" (Blumenthal p.47).

The public, meanwhile, only too happy to oblige (at last to be heard!), fails to recognize the fatal deficiency of the language they have been asked to speak. It has been specifically designed to contain only those concepts, arranged in just those ways, which

The public, only too happy at last to be heard, fails to recognize the fatal deficiency of the language they have been asked to speak

allow the public to express the will which the government has decided it ought to have. As Bernays notes about his own techniques that "[whereas] under the old salesmanship the manufacturer said to the prospective purchaser, 'Please buy a piano,' [t]he new salesmanship has reversed the process and caused the prospective purchaser to say to the manufacturer, 'Please sell me a piano,'" so the new techniques of political polling reduces what appears to be a "government by the people" to the governmental self-affirmation of the status quo (Bernays p.48). By providing the ideological holes through which opinion is allowed to flow, the binary poll shapes the opinion itself, as water takes the shape of its conduit; by prior linguistic arrangement, the public requests exactly and only what the government is prepared to provide.

This constant projection onto the people of the acceptable categories of communication brings into existence an ideological grid, by reference to the axes of which the individual is asked to identify himself. Self-location, alignment in this or another conceptual space, therefore becomes the key element in democratic participation. It is more than semantic coincidence that one's opinion of, and position on, a given issue are one and the same thing. In the reduction of the self to the set of political coordinates by which it is defined, "the individual body becomes an element that may be placed, moved...;" character, or even opinion, are no longer essential marks of the individual, "but the space it occupies, the interval it covers."

By prior linguistic arrangement, the public requests exactly and only what the government is prepared to provide

In this way the democratic process becomes a dehumanizing ritual, whereby the self is systematically stripped of any and all characteristics which disturb the unity and simplicity of the binary political universe. To enter the ideological playing field of modern democracy–for the individual, that is, to be declared politically (and therefore socially, and therefore actually) legitimate–is to redefine the self by reference to the terms of the political game. The self essentially *is* an ideological space-holder, an ordinal pair of political coordinates, representing nothing more than the means by which the status quo is eventually reinforced, when the distribution of individuals throughout the political grid is officially recorded in the periodic ballot. By opening a determinate space into which the individual is to fit, by which the individual is to be defined, the self is carefully fabricated into the social order, reflecting the characteristics of that order, fulfilling the function of its position. The individual becomes "a cell in the social organism," which, although distinct from the whole in that it can be named, (to be nameable is to be completely known, for the self possesses no more complicated characteristic than its location), nevertheless its entire significance comes from the way in which it is "organized into a social unit" as a function of the vote it represents (Bernays p.28).

By lifting from the citizen the need for active political participation, by defining and presenting the issues to the public in a rigid binary form, by no longer requiring the individual to work to bring conceptual order out of ideological chaos, the binary system renders superfluous the very capacity for conceptualization. Democratic "participation" becomes self- contradictory, and so is reduced to the far less active "allegiance," with the significance of the individual completely expressed as a merely biological metaphor for the vote. For allegiance is nothing more than self location, for the express purpose of the official enumeration to follow. The entire political purpose–the raison d'*être*–of the individual is captured in its countability.

The symbol for this "allegiance" is the clapping in the midst of a speech, the sole purpose of which is to locate, identify, and label an individual, to display the supportive soil in which he is potted. It is the Congress during the "debate" over our participation in the Gulf, or during the State of the Union address. The clapping, itself only one leg of the binary disjunction "approve/disapprove," defines its aural opposite (the failure to clap) into its ideological opposite by the sheer force of its obviousness. Silence is forced into signification, and the laws of binary political logic dictate its opposition to the ideology of noise.

Such a dynamic could not be possible if political debate itself had not become a largely meaningless ritual, thereby leaving a void to be filled by the designated meanings of noise and silence. By moving the focus of debate away from the process of defining the issues (for the issues have been pre-defined) to the facilitation of alignment, debate has become nothing more than a formal procedure for arriving at the pre-ordained conclusion. Once the boundaries of an issue are set, once the question has been phrased, the appropriate position is obvious–

manifest in the definitional parameters themselves. Seriously to believe otherwise is to neglect the extent to which Mr. Chaika's "yes" is contained in the plebescite itself. It is to ignore the extent to which, in a congressional debate in which the only options were war and peace, the actual outcome was the determined one.

For it is not only the set of possible responses to ideological questions which have become binary; the concepts through and by which these questions are constructed have been bifurcated to fit more neatly into the political discourse required by the binary poll. The allowable concepts must have easily available (or at least constructable) opposites, and these oppositions must be scrupulously maintained. For with the possibility of conceptual synthesis, of original mixture, arises the possibility of alternative response options, and this must be avoided for it shatters the very framework on which this conceptual universe rests. Consider again the congressional 'debate' over the use of force in the Middle East. Perhaps my insistence that the choice for war is actually determined by the binary opposition "war/peace" seems foolish. Surely that opposition exhausts all possible options, making the choice between them a necessary (but surely not pre-determined) first step to any policy. This, however, is exactly the point, for this conceptual pair is only truly exhaustive of all possible options if the sole content of the word "peace" is "not war." By being defined against (and hence, in terms of) its opposite, "peace" becomes a negative concept denoting lack of, cessation. Without positive content of its own, peace is no longer a viable option in the face of US goals and objectives. Inaction cannot achieve. If it were a positive concept, an idea with life and direction of its own origination, it could not conveniently serve as the opposite to war (and war needs an opposite to fill the other side of the ideological ballot). The positive meanings of peace (and other concepts) thus have had to be jettisoned, leaving our political language critically impoverished. In the politicians' lexicon, the only entry under "peace" reads "see: war."

This constant reproduction of the same concepts can only result in the degeneration of these concepts. As the constant reproduction of identical genes results in the regression of a species, so this restriction of the range of political discourse, by disallowing the opportunity for creative variation, for conceptual evolution–for evolution is essentially a destruction of previously existing categorical boundaries–likewise results in the degenerative regression of conceptual integrity. Defining each concept in the terms of another (so better to maintain their discrete opposition) actually results in a breakdown of the very distinction the opposition was meant to preserve.

Creative combination, and conceptual progress is thus replaced by the destructive collapse of the binary opposition itself. When more and more tightly interdefined, the concepts slowly merge, blurring into one another until they are rendered the meaningless markers of some pair of axes, locked into position somewhere inside the ideological grid. Consider the oft cited phrases "peace-keeper missile" and "nuclear deterrence" (the doctrine that the best way to promote peace is by developing more efficient means by which to wage war), or, if you tire of these examples, some phrases from The *New York Times*: "patriotism means supporting the war," and "One prominent group supporting the war effort has been the Committee for Peace..." Surely these phrases all have their contextual meanings, but such meaning is generated solely by understanding the concepts involved in terms of what seems to be the contradictory interdefinition that is slowly decimating the range of our political discourse. Although we have not begun, in true Orwellian fashion, to assert the unity of opposites, the fact that supporting peace can now mean encouraging war, and can certainly mean supporting the proliferation of ever-more destructive weapons, symbolizes in the public a rather disturbing degree of comfort with the conceptual oxymorons which abound in the language of politics.

Not the least significant of these collapsing oppositions is that of the two party system itself. Each candidate, when "measuring" the public attitude, must, in order to be elected, stand at the nexus of that opinion. Although one may create many publics, there can be at most one majority, and so party platforms begin of necessity to migrate to the same center. So an institution which may once have provided for the dynamic synthesis of opposites required for true and fertile conceptual process becomes, in the contemporary situation, a way to apply two different names

to the same reinforcement of the *status quo*. The distinction between Democrat and Republican is virtually non-existent. Even the words themselves have lost their meaning–to win the 1988 election Bush had to label his opponent by the pejorative tag "liberal" (which, of course, was a convenient linguistic stand-in for "tax," thus collapsing one more conceptual/linguistic distinction) for nobody knows what "Democrat" is supposed to mean anymore, except that it designates that which is not Republican. Likewise, "Republican" has no more sophisticated content than non-Democrat, and so together the terms collapse into a mutually interdefined nothingness.

Unfortunately, even the calls for political variety do not offer much hope of escape from this rapidly collapsing ideological universe. Such cries smack of commodified requests for a different, more appealing label on the same old product, for a diagonal "NEW!" placed in the corner of a politician's public profile. Although these voices may embody the distant echo of protest against the constant emaciation of our political language, of outrage over concepts made empty through histories of contradictory usage, the cynic (realist?) cannot help but note the direction and speed of the fall, and wonder whether reversal is possible, or even desirable.

The vote has not just been replaced by the media poll, but has become a meaningless action symbolic of a meaningless political process

For by moving the burden of democratic participation from the creation and manipulation of political ideology to allegiance with pre-defined conceptual sets, by reducing the import of the individual to a countable place-marker located somewhere on the ideological grid, by restricting the range of available political language so better to maneuver opinion into apparent agreement with current policy (and in so doing, moving from the era of the pre-packaged candidate to the era of the manufactured public), by forcing allowable concept into a mold of binary interdefinition, and by endorsing the process embodied in the collapse of conceptual, linguistic, and therefore actual distinctions, a democracy so dominated by the binary media poll sows the seeds of its own destruction. Is it so surprising that voter turnout is at its all-time low, and still dropping? The vote has not just been replaced, rendered superfluous by the media poll, but has become a meaningless action symbolic of a meaningless political process, the functioning of which relies on the manipulation and dissemination of meaningless concepts. Even allegiance itself becomes an empty gesture exactly in so far as the options one is requested to consider are mutually interdefinable. With each answer essentially indistinguishable, any feeling of the purposeful contribution of self expression is quickly lost. In some real sense, political apathy is the product of, even demanded by, the current democratic system, but the fact remains that no democratic system can survive the complete alienation of the populace. So, as surely as linguistic oppositions fade into meaningless conceptual unity, the meaning of democracy is itself collapsing into something quite other. I urge you, therefore, carefully to analyze the unfolding events and strategies of the upcoming presidential election campaign, for in no other process will the true state of our union be more visible. The final definition–the eventual meaning of American democracy yet rests in the hands of the reader.

Notes

1 Lord Bryce, *The American Commonwealth*, Vol. II (MacMillan & Co., Ltd.: London) 1888, p. 220.
2 Francis X. Clines, "Latvia & Estonia Vote on Sovereignty," *The New York Times*, March 4, 1991.
3 That these polls are a central and necessary part of the political process is something that I will, for the purpose of this article, take for granted. For an excellent account of just how and why they have become politically essential, see Sydney Blumenthal's *The Permanent Campaign* (Simon and Schuster: New York) 1982.
4 Hans Spier, "The Rise of Public Opinion," *Propaganda and Communication in World History*, Vol. II (The University Press of Hawaii: Honolulu) 1980, pp. 147-167 and Paul A. Palmer, "The Concept of Public Opinion in Political Theory," *Essays in History and Political Theory in Honor of Charles H. McIlwain*, (Russell & Russell: New York) 1967, pp. 230-257.
5 Jeremy Bentham, *The Works of Jeremy Bentham*, John Bowring, ed., (Edinburgh, 1838-1843), IX, p. 168.
6 Jeremy Bentham, "Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation," *The Works of Jeremy Bentham*, I, p. 464.
7 Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *Considerations about the Government of Poland*.
8 Edward L. Bernays, *The Engineering of Consent*, (Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Sciences), 1947.
9 Edward L. Bernays, *Propaganda*, (Horace Liveright: New York) 1928, p. 19.
10 Michel Foucault, *Discipline and Punish*, Alan Sheridan, trans., (Vintage Books: New York), 1979, p. 164.

Toward a World Government

17

George Collins

In the wake of a war that wrought unprecedented destruction on a distant nation, it is worth reflecting on the origins of war in general to discover what international arrangements could be adopted to avert tragedy such as the Gulf War in the future. This, after all, is the promise underlying the "new world order" that President Bush has heralded. Some have argued that humanity's tendency to fight wars is rooted in inborn aggressive drives and that people must learn, therefore, to live with the specter of continuous war. The evidence, however, indicates that large-scale conflict among men is essentially a product of civilized living. Hope consequently remains that a remedy may be found for this illness that has so long plagued mankind. The solution lies in establishing a governing body that has significant authority over all of the nations of the world. The United Nations, as the modern incarnation of this ideal, has thus far fallen short, but it may provide the groundwork for the creation of a stronger international authority.

Some arguments put forward by sociobiologists, psychologists, and philosophers suggest that man is fundamentally war-like, as if he were some sort of killer ape. If we examine the evidence carefully, however, the opposite seems to be true: man has evolved as an essentially cooperative, social animal, and for most of his existence, belligerent war-making would have been incompatible with his survival. Before people settled down into agricultural villages about 10,000 years ago, they had lived for millennia as nomadic hunters and gatherers. During this time human nature, however minimal, must have developed. Simple inferences made from archaeological findings as well as ethnographic observations of modern hunting and gathering peoples suggest that relations among individuals and groups were grounded in sharing and cooperation rather than competition and slavish obedience to leadership. Conflicts initiated by people in this condition would have been limited in scale (perhaps arising from arguments between individuals) and would have tended to push small bands apart, thereby limiting the potential for further antagonism.[1] Any individual who sought to dominate others or attempted to horde the band's goods would have been subject to ostracism. In this way, peaceful egalitarianism was preserved. Small groups often shared whatever excess food they collected with other bands, so that in time of need they could count on a reciprocal favor.[2] In view of all this, there would have been few if any incentives to attack other groups. Many anthropologists have rejected the caricature of the "noble savage," but with regard to early people, it is widely acknowledged that the way of life of early people, although far from idyllic, was much more peaceful and harmonious than our own. In view of all of these findings, it is almost certain that the discord and strife known by humanity now did not arise as a feature of this pre-historic past.

How, then, did war become so ingrained in settled societies? People probably began to settle down and farm for several reasons, but chief among these were the pressures exerted by a growing population on finite food resources. Farming provided the means of supplying the growing demand.[3] Arable land, however, located in the fertile areas surrounding major rivers, was in short

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supply. This shortage alone provided the conditions for some conflict, as villagers in a fertile zone might have resisted encroachment of their land by other communities that could not support themselves on the land available.[4] Besides this cause for tension arose, who became increasingly dictatorial over time and who gained the power to direct their subjects to attack other peoples. In the beginning these leaders had merely organized the community's labor in the fields and controlled the distribution of the harvest. In time, however, they solidified their position (which often became hereditary) and demanded a portion of the people's labors.[5] When communities led by such men sprouted up in close proximity, one to another, wars (organized, large-scale attacks and defenses, not mere raids or skirmishes) were fought for the first time. The leader of one community probably decided to attack a neighbor to gain needed land or resources, to enlarge his labor-force, or to gain control of trade routes.[6] The inhabitants of a besieged town had few options: they could submit and perhaps suffer enslavement, they could flee, or they could resist with force. Submission and escape were rarely not appealing options, so the attacked people often resisted conquest.[7] Indeed, after the pattern of aggressive conquest was established, the defensive peoples may have become offensive to preserve their security. We see in this simple scenario the motivations underlying most of modern warfare between nation-states. The wars which have brought untold suffering to succeeding generations are, therefore, a product of the system of settled communities. As long as there is no restraining authority on the leadership of states, people will go to war, for the same motivations that provoked the first wars still exist. It is an ironic commentary on human nature that thousands or even millions will cooperate in great national war efforts which aim to destroy other people similarly engaged.

As long as states may disregard the legislation of the UN and protect themselves as they see fit, there is little hope for a lasting, universal peace

Now, perhaps more than ever, people want to establish a stable and lasting peace. Obviously humanity cannot and will not return to the hunting and foraging life. It is necessary, therefore, to find a solution that takes into account the realities of the world scene today. There is evidence that people of different nationalities can overcome their differences and live in unity. The European Community, for example, represents the union of nations that have fought amongst themselves for centuries. The diverse states and peoples of America have similarly managed to exist in relative peace. What is common to these examples is that the separate states have yielded authority, at least partially, to a supra-national governing body. Whether the unity is one of confederation, federation, or imperial control, the authority to enforce order among the states lies in a central government. Only in this way have peoples of diverse state and ethnic origins been able to live in harmony. Of course, maintaining order in a union of heterogeneous peoples such as the Soviet Union or India can prove extremely difficult. Frictions between nationalities due to longstanding contentions– land, religion, historical injustice– can, however, be addressed by the supreme governing body. If a government has been established by the member states for the common welfare, then it is the duty of such a government to settle disputes of this kind. It is evident that separate states, even those who have been antagonists through history, can live in relative peace if they relinquish some power to a higher authority.

The promise of the United Nations was originally intended to be an international authority capable of preserving peace among nations. So far, the UN has not lived up to the ideals of its founders because member states have not yielded enough authority to it. The United Nations lacks the power to enforce many of its resolutions, and it has been used selectively by the great powers when it suits their own interests. For example, over the years the United States has frequently reneged on its promises to provide the with needed funds. Clearly, a government that cannot depend on a reliable source of revenues is not much of a government at all. Primarily because of this insufficient commitment of member states, the UN has not lived up to its potential as a form of world government. Of course, the union of nations that it could bring about according to its charter would be loose. In this arrangement, member states would still retain virtually complete sovereignty as well as the right to self-defense. In the short term, this arrangement may be the only one agreeable to the peoples of the world. Clearly, a world governing body will need more authority than that with which the UN is invested. As long as states may disregard the legislation of the UN and protect themselves as they see fit, there is little hope for a lasting, universal peace. A world governing body must

have the power that national governments retain. It must have the power to back up its decisions with force if necessary. It must also limit or eliminate the military capabilities of its member nations. States can always justify a war by claiming that it is fought in self-defense. A world government, consequently, must be allowed to prohibit the use of force entirely and to guarantee protection for any nation or country that is attacked by another. Only by acquiring enough real power, both military and political, could a world government effectively preserve international peace and enforce its laws.

The countries of the world must form a binding contract among themselves to establish this higher authority. This agreement is analogous to the social contract envisioned by political philosophers, such as Hobbes and Locke, in which individuals come together and designate a governing authority to rule over them. The individual yields his right to absolute freedom to this authority because he recognizes the benefits of peace he will gain from such a transference. According to this theory, such an arrangement is inevitable, for men, being rational, realize the dangers associated without a higher authority. We must hope that the peoples of the world will arrive at a similar conclusion and make a similar contract. Humanity, otherwise, faces the grim possibility of annihilating itself through weapons of mass destruction. We may not have sufficient reason to be positively optimistic about the prospects for such an arrangement, but neither can we be pessimistic. There is ample evidence from history and contemporary politics that multinational unities are possible. And we may dismiss suggestions that people are innately aggressive and prone to violence. In these times, however, we cannot expect the nations of the world to come together spontaneously and form this compact. Such an ideal must be pursued vigorously and urgently. Now that people are beginning to understand the causes of their wars, they must seize on every opportunity to avert further unnecessary destruction. Such an opportunity is now presenting itself.

Notes

1 Marvin Harris, *Cannibals and Kings: The Origins of Cultures* (New York: Random House, 1977), 34.

2 John E. Pfeiffer, *The Emergence of Society* (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1977), 61-64.

3 Harris, 24-26.

4 Bruce Bower, "Gauging the Winds of War," *Science News*, 139 (February 9, 1991), 88.

5 Harris, 76-78.

6 Bower, 89.

7 Schmookler, Andrew, *The Parable of the Tribes: The Problem of Power in Social Evolution* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984), 21-22.

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The Collapse of American Values

Linette Hwu

It is especially important in this time of glory and heroism that we direct our vision inwards and take a look in the mirror, for our success on the international front has little or no meaning if at home reasons exist for us to hang our heads in shame. Certainly this is the case, for a study of our society–out times and our mores, to quote Cicero–which does not simply gloss over the surface but instead penetrates that shiny veneer of feel-good, happy-go-lucky American optimism, enthusiasm, and confidence, reveals an alarming lack of morality.

What is morality? The second college edition of Webster's *New World Dictionary* defines it as "the character of being in accord with the principles or standards of right conduct." Because each individual has his own set of ethics, Webster's definition of morality would seem to take on different dimensions depending on the individual. No, a more practical way to define morality would be to equate it with rationality and to call the person moral who uses his mind and his ability to think, unique to the human race, in search of the highest level of excellence he can attain. Each individual must, therefore, add to his ethical conviction the strength of his mind; he must temper his mind with careful and logical mental activity. In this way, it is possible to fulfill the responsibility which the possession of a mind devolves upon each person. According to this definition, the moral deficiency present in the United States is clear, for people are abandoning thought for reaction–to their hearts, to their personal feelings, to their gut instincts, to society's mandates. They are not recognizing the best when it is offered to them, or perhaps worse, they are recognizing it and passing it up. They are reneging on their birthright and on their obligation as thinking beings to see that the human mind does not evolve into a nonfunctional, and hence useless, part of the body. This is inexcusable, but more important, it is laying the foundations for the fall of America from the status of a world-power as rapid as its rise to it.

Our leaders are setting the example. To see that this is so, one need only observe how the word "politician" has such negative connotations for many people. Why is this the case in our democracy, in our system of "government of the people, for the people, and by the people?" At the root of the problem is the fact that the American public regards government as an institution too far away to do any real good for the country, and government officials as individuals who will say or do anything, that is, pretend anything, to get elected to office and stay there.

For the most part, the American public is not judging harshly. Many government officials are more concerned with securing their jobs in the state or federal capital than with fulfilling the duties of their positions, that is, with serving the public–and their own consciences–by putting their minds to better use. They pay lip service to their constituents and ingratiate themselves with those who are even more powerful than they. They look away hastily when the opportunity to take a stand and be a leader, a statesman, and not just a politician, lies in supporting an unpopular issue, such as the right to burn the American flag. Each pays close attention to public opinion polls

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and then comes out as the champion and last defender of this right or the crusader against that injury to good ol' American values. They become entangled in all sorts of financial dealings, even illegal, to promote themselves and to collect campaign funds. Perhaps they enact or sponsor a token piece of legislation, but more often than not, their primary interest is to play the game of politics in order to take care of their own futures.

Is this any way for public servants to be spending their time? These are our *leaders*, and yet their roles can hardly be called leadership roles. Instead, they are caught up in a web of power games and partisan manipulation, driven irrationally and obsessively with paving the way for the success of their political careers. Is it any wonder that the voters find fault with government bureaucracy, especially after the complete rearrangement of the Democratic hierarchy in the House of Representatives over two years ago, or the disclosure of scandal after scandal during the Reagan administration, or the lessons history teaches us about Grant's administration and city bosses?

And yet, the voters must receive some of the blame as well. They threaten defeat in the election for representatives who vote themselves a pay raise in an attempt to ease financial worries, thus landing their government officials in no-win situations. They decry the budget deficit and then refuse to accept either higher taxes or spending cuts, unable to grasp the concept that "there is no free lunch," and as a result, leave each politician crying "Not in my district" and forsaking national interest for his own political future, launching months of partisan debate on Capitol Hill. In the end, they overwhelmingly indicate their confidence in their incumbents on Election Day (not that any newcomer to politics with the firm intent to maintain his morals at all costs would stand a chance in the ruthless, backstabbing atmosphere of government). The government reflects thus the flaws in the character of an American public which votes on the basis of superficial qualities such as physical appearance, media image, and empty promises rather than on the abilities of intellect and the potential the candidate has to be an effective member of the government. It is a vicious cycle to which both the politicians and the public contribute and which turns government into an unproductive machine and defeats the purpose of its existence, for government now benefits no one.

"Greed is good." So claims stock-market wizard Gordon Gekko in the film Wall Street. He goes on: "Greed works. Greed clarifies, cuts through, and captures the essence of the evolutionary spirit. Greed in all of its forms, greed for life, for money, for love, for knowledge, has marked the upward surge of mankind, and greed ... will save ... [the] malfunctioning corporation called the USA." Gordon Gekko is right. Greed, however, can take on both a moral and an immoral form, and too often it takes on the latter. Today we see the junk-bond dealer and the manufacturer who cuts corners, just as in the past we saw men with no concern for their human labor. In their effort to make a quick buck, these individuals, like their counterparts in government, forget that their duty is to the customer–the public–first, and that only afterwards can and *will* true personal profit come. Worst of all, they are forgetting wherein lies the value of money, for money is completely devoid of any meaning unless it is a reward for the triumph of a superior ability (whether that ability belong to a garbage collector or a scientific innovator), not for the destruction the lives of fellow human beings, nor for the obsequiousness shown to the corporate executives, nor for the underhandedness displayed by those pulling strings in every corner of the industry.

Because, however, immoral greed predominates in the American business world, and because the financial aspect frequently is of prime concern to American entrepreneurs, large or small, the US is losing its competitive edge to Japan and Western Europe in international markets. It is not impossible for a company to care for its employees, produce high-quality goods, and make a handsome profit at the same time; the Japanese and the Western Europeans have shown this to be feasible. They understand that they cannot separate the three and do not require a choice among them. Instead they consider high quality the well-being of their labor and profit to be interdependent and combined, and their industry proves unbeatable. These foreign powers, in social Darwinian terms, will prove the fittest and win the battle for economic survival as Charles Darwin theorized because their industries emphasize first the quality of the products they manufacture with the certain knowledge that economic security will follow, and because they are willing to take

risks to, risks which the US took during its period of rapid industrial growth and which now frighten the security-anxious US immeasurably.

The US industry today shies away from the competition which it once glorified and sought, because such competition points only to the gradual destruction of industry's own existence. The law of evolution is at work, and yet there are those who would halt the march of time, by urging us to "buy American," a plea that should be heeded only if American products are better. These people are deluded with their questionable interpretation of patriotism and are actually hurting the country they love so much and are so eager to protect, for they are prolonging an agony which will only increase in intensity unless American business undergoes a fundamental reversal of values. Our only hope is to improve the quality of our products to the point where "Made in America" once again means that one has bought the best in the market. Then nothing will be able to stop us, not protectionism, not foreign trading blocs with their extensive regulation or their high taxes, for the United States is itself a huge market that is currently and unfortunately being over-tapped by outside economic powers. Gordon Gekko's "upward surge of mankind" will be hindered by an attempt by American industry to corner the market of achievements. Yet greed, for lack of a better word, will indeed save the United States if its businessmen crusade for excellence with the abilities of the human brain, a belief in the continual progress of humanity, and a greed for excellence and its accompanying benefits, in that order, as their sole weapons.

America is the land of opportunity, yes, but that means personal initiative to the chances that are offered, not waiting around for success to appear on the doorstep

The law of evolution must be allowed to take its course within the country as well. It is of no benefit to the US if people who make no contribution to society are nonetheless permitted to feed off of it, and yet this is exactly what social welfare attempts to do in its sloppy and sometimes useless way. The social welfare system punishes those individuals with the resources to produce by taking away the reward for their ability–their money–and giving it to those who are unable or unwilling to produce and are, therefore, a burden to society. This is immorality at its highest, and it can be neither justified nor tolerated. A social welfare system, if it exists at all, should act solely as a safety net to help those who are struggling, those who are fighting for life, those who are putting forth every ounce of energy in their bodies to survive and are finding it difficult simply because of the high cost of living in our country. It should not be a lifeline for those who use their welfare checks for alcohol or any other kind of drug, nor for those who sit around and do nothing all day and every day because they know they can continue to live without the slightest bit of effort, because they have "a bottomless sense of entitlement to federal money," as P.J. O'Rourke writes in *Parliament of Whores*. America is the land of opportunity, yes, but that means personal initiative to the chances that are offered, not waiting around for success to appear on the doorstep, be required before offering people a special chance.

Using similar reasoning, the faults of Affirmative Action are obvious, for the program tries to insure minorities equal access to employment by mandating that an employer hire the minority if two candidates for a position are equal in all aspects except race or sex. Right away, the logic on the part of Affirmative Action advocates is flawed, for although "all men are created equal," there is nothing in the law of evolution which guarantees such equality beyond birth. What an individual is willing to do with his abilities in life determines whether or not he is able to succeed. This issue has nothing to do with civil rights and civil liberties as a human being, but it has everything to do with who becomes a creator and therefore leaves a stamp on the world after he has passed. Only those with the capacity to make such an impact, regardless of race or sex, should be granted the opportunities to do so. Simple arithmetic dictates that in a room of one-hundred persons, fifty of them are below average; is it right that the fifty-first person should take away the chance of the fiftieth simply by virtue of his being a minority? Does this do justice to anyone's ability? Exactly as a capable person will feel no incentive to give a task his all if he knows he will lose a promotion to a minority, so a less capable individual will not give a task his all if he knows that half the effort will earn him the promotion. Does this contribute to the "upward surge of mankind?" Although it is true that racial and sexual discrimination still exist in this country, employers and educators who are truly attempting to produce the best possible products and people cannot afford to sacrifice the intelligent, ambitious, and

competent worker and student for the sake of outdated stereotypes. Ability and the use of that ability should be the only standards used to judge a person.

Human relationships, however, are also marred by a superficial and insignificant quality which is despicable. Many friendships are hardly worthy of the appellation, for they involve no true interaction of the mind and the soul. Instead, they often consist of pseudo-smiles and pseudo-conversations and are founded not on the basis of any mutual respect for personal attributes but on the basis of how the semblance of a relationship will benefit one's position. Take a look at the New York society as described by Yale graduate Tom Wolfe in The Bonfire *of the Vanities*, or as the similar society depicted by Edith Wharton in *The House of Mirth*. Love, furthermore, is rarely ever love, but the solely physical gratification of sex with the absence of any more profound feeling, which so easily–and so wrongly–doubles as love. This is why extra-marital affairs occur and have occurred; the only change today is that they are more often followed by the breakup of marriages and families. This further deteriorates the support unit for young children growing up and causes the failure to provide them with a sound base of values for their education. Badmouthing and backstabbing are quite common, while an exchange of thoughts on serious topics and the kind of deep emotional commitment which results from an intense relationship unfortunately are not. This depravity stems from the dearth of security and self-confidence in human beings, which also results in the replacement of individualism and innovation by conformity and mediocrity. The person who stands alone or stands above is hated, feared, and cast out with such passion because the people around him cannot bear to see that he does not need them and do not want to grasp the contempt for them that this implies. That virtues are turned so quickly into sins and are made just as quickly into grounds for aspersions is reprehensible. This, however, is becoming the norm in American society with an ease that is simultaneously frightening and disheartening.

Is it too much to ask that every citizen of the United States use the brain which sets him apart from the other species on the planet to its fullest capacity? If the answer is yes, then indeed this is a sad commentary on humanity. Is this account of current American society exaggerated and too harsh? Perhaps. That the path on which the United States is travelling, however, is leading to a hell as described above cannot be denied. We who have the brain power to comprehend this and the potential to reverse the course must not fail to do so. The responsibility is ours. We owe it to no one else except ourselves and to nothing else except the supposed brilliance of the minds which got us here in the first place.

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